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Art Gallery of Alberta's 2017 biennial refuses to speak for us all, in the very best way



By [Fish Griwkowsky](#)

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Kristopher Karklin's photo, Home — part of the Art Gallery of Alberta's 2017 biennial. PHOTO BY FISH GRIWKOWSKY /Postmedia



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The Art Gallery of Alberta's 10th biennial running through Sept. 10 is called *For the Time Being*, and in the sense of questioning its own authority to speak for others — and in some ways even itself — feels very contemporary, indeed.

In a terrific back and forth between curators Peta Rake and Kristy Trinier called *The End of the World* in the show's catalogue, the two discuss how many dynamic, far-reaching changes have hit both contemporary art and the larger world as a whole in a just a few years, from environmental to political to an ever-eroding sense of traditional gatekeepers and the question of whose stories are being told by whom, and where.



Many biennials are international, but the Art Gallery of Alberta's 20-year tradition has always been provincially focused, so

the curators cleverly brought in outside curators Lorenzo Fusi and Kendal Henry to challenge and provoke the 24 artists, who for the first time met a year in advance to get the conversations going before the art was hanging on the wall.



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In the essay, Trinier talks about the once-secret hangout spot overlooking the river valley known as the End of the World which, once exposed, “led the city to implement regulation and control of the way the site is accessed, with surveys and signage, barricades and plans for a ‘real’ viewing platform, irrevocably altering the informal acts that happen at the site.

“Is this a metaphor,” she continues, “for the contemporary art community as it existed between the fall of 2015 and the summer of 2017? We can see that ‘world’ is over, and a new world will be conceived going forward.”

Also innovative and a bit of a wink at the idea of one institution to rule them all, on June 24 the show's second set of works will open at Walter Phillips Gallery at the Banff Centre. What follows is a look at a few of the pieces here at the Art Gallery of Alberta worth a longer look, many influenced by science fiction, heavy on the metaphors and a bittersweet sense of nostalgia for things that, in some cases, may have never happened in the first place.

Tamara Lee-Anne Cardinal — **Akhop: A Blanket**

Based in Saddle Lake Cree Nation, Cardinal created a traditional star blanket out of hair and herbs used in ceremony although instead of fabric it is made out of white, handmade paper. Hung just over people's heads, the piece was created contemplating the idea Canada was "born" 150 years ago. These blankets signify the "Old Ones," who existed long before most of Canada's ancestors arrived, licking their lips.

Craig Fahner and Neal Moignard — **Smokescreen**

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One screen presents a quick survey where you answer yes or no to questions such as, “Am I happy with my life?” As you answer, an evolving creature based on your answers takes shape on a larger screen (which follows your movements). When your survey — and monster — are finished, you send it out into the world on a third screen, where it twists and dances awkwardly with the other mutants made that day by strangers. Congratulations, you’ve summed up humanity.



Mark Clintberg’s composition Do I Still Cross Your Mind? reflected in a metal serving tray.

Mark Clintberg’s composition Do I Still Cross Your Mind? reflected in a metal serving tray. PHOTO BY FISH GRIWKOWSKY /Postmedia

Mark Clintberg — Do I Still Cross Your Mind?

Three metal serving trays aimed at the ceiling reflect and “straighten” the backwards text above, a throwback of older institutions mirroring frescoes so patrons needn’t strain themselves. But to fully read the text, one must lean in deeply,

and so one's own reflection intrudes. Start
the metaphor machine!

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Kristopher Karklin — Home

This gigantic vinyl print of models playing young Alberta homeowners, naked and staring at the prefab and familiar burden before them, is the show's most direct piece, as even the artificiality before them is fake — a collage of thousands of tiny photos which bring to mind individual bricks, or perhaps \$100 bills, walling them in. Terrifying, really.



Nicole Kelly Westman's video

installation, If You Weren't There â

part of the Art Gallery of Alberta's 2017

biennial.

Nicole Kelly Westman's video installation, If You Weren't There â part of the Art Gallery of Alberta's 2017 biennial. PHOTO BY FISH GRIWKOWSKY /Postmedia

Nicole Kelly Westman — If You Weren't There

A good pairing with Clintberg's trays is this. A flickering movie screen with the piece's melancholy title plays to two empty seats lit up in red, as much a part of the show as the film, given the theme of absence. A little Twin Peaks in the best way, but depending on who you decide the missing "you" is, this is a serious little room to contemplate who you are, with and without others.

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by Taboola

Where: Art Gallery of Alberta, 2 Sir
Winston Churchill Square

When: Through Sept. 10

Admission: \$12.50 general admission;
youth + students free; general admission
free Tuesday and Wednesday nights 5 to 8
p.m



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